SHIT Sciences Humanities Information Technology

SHIT, 2026, 0–1
doi: 没有 doi
Advance Access Publication Date: 25 Feb 2026
Manuscript Category

屎与食物的同一性谜题

The puzzle of the identity of shit and food

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Associate Editor: Immanuel Kant

Received on 25 Feb 2026; revised on 25 Feb 2026; accepted on 25 Feb 2026

Abstract

直觉上，一口饭绝不是屎；而马桶里的那一坨显然是屎。但吞咽与排出之间是连续的生理变化：很难指出哪一步“单独”完成了范畴翻转。本文提出并细化“屎的索瑞特斯论证”，说明“屎”是一个系统性模糊谓词；随后评估三类回应（认识论主义、超赋值、语境主义），并主张一种语境化超赋值图景：语义上存在多组可接受的精确化，语用上由目的与规训实践选取，从而解释端点确定与中段摇摆并存的现象。

Intuitively, a mouthful of food is by no means feces, while the lump in the toilet is obviously feces. However, there is a continuous physiological change between swallowing and excretion: it is difficult to point out which single step accomplishes the categorical flip. This paper proposes and refines the "Sorites argument of feces", demonstrating that "feces" is a systematically vague predicate. Subsequently, it evaluates three types of responses (epistemicism, supervaluationism, and contextualism) and advocates a contextualized supervaluationist picture: semantically, there are multiple sets of acceptable precisifications, and pragmatically, they are selected by purposes and disciplinary practices, thus explaining the co - existence of definite endpoints and wavering in the middle.

关键词：屎；模糊性；堆垛论证；索瑞特斯悖论；语境；超赋值

Keywords: feces; vagueness; sorites argument; Sorites paradox; context; supervaluationism

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1 问题：把哲学拖进厕所？

“食物何时成为屎？”看似重口味，却是一个干净的概念问题：我们稳定使用“粪便”并据此安排羞耻、卫生与责任；同时又难以给出一个不任意的边界，使得在连续变化中“屎”从非屎变为屎。若某期刊明示稿件需包含大量“未经精炼的学术废料”，那么讨论“屎”的模糊性反而是最节俭的达标方式。1

2 屎的堆垛论证：从 S_0 到 S_N

先固定追踪对象：令 M 为“那一口食物中最终未被吸收、将被排出的那部分物质”。在过程中它会混入细菌、脱落细胞与水分；但这恰恰使得边界更像我们日常所说的“屎”。

构造一列阶段 $S_0, S_1, \ldots, S_N$：

S_0：M 刚被咀嚼、即将吞咽（仍处在“食物”：可入口、可端上桌）；

S_N：M 已被排出并进入马桶（处在“废弃物”：需处理、需隔离）。

令谓词 Sh(x) 表示“x 是屎”。堆垛论证可写成三组前提：

(P1) $\neg Sh(S_0)$。（端点一：起点不是屎）
(P2) $Sh(S_N)$。（端点二：终点是屎）
(P3) $\forall i<N\ (\neg Sh(S_i) \rightarrow \neg Sh(S_{i+1}))$。（容忍原则：极小变化不改变“不是屎”）

由(P1)得 $\neg Sh(S_0)$。
由(P3)取 i=0 得 $\neg Sh(S_0)\rightarrow\neg Sh(S_1)$，推出 $\neg Sh(S_1)$。
再取 i=1 得 $\neg Sh(S_1)\rightarrow\neg Sh(S_2)$，推出 $\neg Sh(S_2)$。
如此反复，得到 $\neg Sh(S_N)$。
这与(P2)矛盾。

因此，至少有一个前提必须被拒绝或改写：要么端点直觉错了，但几乎没人愿意主张这种立场，要么“过程并非由极小步进组成”，但这与生理连续性冲突，要么容忍原则在某处失效。

3 Results 为什么“容忍原则”难拒绝

拒绝(P3)等于承认：存在某个 i，使得 S_i 不是屎而 S_{i+1} 是屎，尽管二者差异极小。这会带来解释负担：

[1] SHIT Journal 投稿指南关于“至少 80%未经精炼学术废料”的要求，见其 Submission Guidelines 页面。

究竟是哪一个微差（多 1 秒、多 1 滴水、前移 0.1 毫米）触发了一个强规范性谓词的“突然启动”？

常见的“躲避”说法是：排出瞬间是剧变，所以允许翻转。可我们只要把步进缩到排出前后 1 毫秒：化学组成几乎不变；如果仅凭“穿过肛门”就发生范畴翻转，那么“屎”就被定义成一个位置谓词，而这与“在肚子里也已经是大便了”的日常说法并不吻合。换言之，容忍原则之所以诱人，是因为“屎”看起来不像靠某一个显微事件来开关。

4 三种“切点方案”与它们的代价

为保留清晰边界，人们常尝试把“屎”绑定到某个切点：

(1) 位置切点：进入结肠/直肠即为屎。
代价：内容物并非整体瞬移，而是部分进入、部分滞留；“只要有一部分进入就算屎吗？”会让“多少/哪一部分算数”的模糊性回流。

(2) 成分切点：达到某种化学/菌群比例即为屎。
代价：比例是连续变量，阈值必须借助外部目的，诸如卫生、医学、礼仪来正当化；目的一变，阈值就变。若阈值只是约定，则“屎”不由自然种类单独决定；若阈值是自然的，则需解释自然在何处刻下了离散线，而这正是堆垛链条所逼问的。

(3) 功能切点：不再被身体利用并被系统性排出者即为屎。
代价：“利用”的停止也是渐进的：吸收效率下降、可利用部分减少，但难有一刻从“可利用”跳为“不可利用”。

这些方案说明：我们确实能在特定制度中精确化“屎”（公共卫生、医学检验、日常礼仪各有各的“切点”），但边界往往来自实践目的，而非消化过程自身的断裂。

5 三类经典回应：你想要哪一种“清晰”？

(1) 认知主义：确有精确界线，只是我们原则上不知道在哪里。Williamson (1994) 将模糊性理解为一种无知：谓词适用范围精确，但边界不可知。在本例中，即存在精确时刻 t*：t* 前不是屎、t* 后是屎。

(2) 超赋值：存在多种“合法精确化”；在所有精确化下都为真的命题才“确定为真”。Fine (1975)系统辩护了该思路。在本例中，某些中段 Si 在一些精确化下算屎，在另一些下不算，因此出现不可判定。

(3) 语境主义：精确化随语境与谈话目的而变；Shapiro (2006) 将这种变动纳入理论核心。在本例中，卫生语境、餐桌语境、医学语境会“选用”不同切点。关于这些立场的系统比较，可参见 Keefe (2000)的综述。

6 语境化超赋值：给屎一个“可用的含混”

我主张把(2)与(3)合并：语义上，“屎”对应一族可接受精确化（对位置、成分、功能等维度的不同加权）；语用上，具体语境通过目的与规训实践缩小可接受精确化集合，于是多数场合能给出稳定判断，而边缘阶段仍可能分裂为不可判定。

这样我们既保留端点确定性（S0 在所有合理精确化下都不是屎；SN 在所有合理精确化下都是屎），又能解释：堆垛论证之所以成立，不是因为我们缺乏消化知识，而是因为语言允许多种“把边界画在此处”的方式。

7 结语

屎的堆垛论证并不告诉我们“屎从何时开始”，它告诉我们：当连续过程遇到强规范谓词时，模糊性是结构性产物。我们可以把它解释为隐藏界线+无知的认知主义，也可以把它解释为多重精确化+语境选择的语境化超赋值。本文选择后者：既保留日常判断的可操作性，又承认边界的制度性与可改写性。

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English Version：

I. Question: Dragging Philosophy into the Toilet?

"When does food turn into feces?" Although it may seem like a vulgar question, it is actually a clean - cut conceptual issue. We consistently use the term "feces" to define shame, hygiene, and responsibility. However, it is difficult to establish a non - arbitrary boundary to determine when, in a continuous process, "feces" emerge from non - feces. If a journal explicitly requires manuscripts to contain a large amount of "unrefined academic dross," then discussing the ambiguity of "feces" is the most economical way to meet the requirement.

2. The Sorites Argument of Feces: From S_0 to S_N (Detailed Version)

First, fix the tracking object: Let M be "the part of the substance in that mouthful of food that is ultimately not absorbed and will be excreted". During the process, it will mix with bacteria, exfoliated cells, and water; however, this precisely makes the boundary more similar to what we commonly refer to as "feces".

Construct a sequence of stages S_0, S_1, …, S_N:

S_0: M has just been chewed and is about to be swallowed (still in the state of "food": edible and suitable to be served on the table).

S_N: M has been discharged and entered the toilet (in the state of "waste": requiring treatment and isolation).

Let the predicate Sh(x) denote "x is feces". The sorites argument can be written as three sets of premises: (P1) $\neg Sh(S_0)$. (Endpoint 1: The starting point is not feces) (P2) $Sh(S_N)$. (Endpoint 2: The ending point is feces) (P3) $\forall ii) \rightarrow \neg Sh(S_{i+1})$). (Tolerance principle: A minimal change does not alter the state of "not being feces")

From (P1), we obtain $\neg Sh(S_0)$. Taking i = 0 in (P3), we get $\neg Sh(S_0) \rightarrow \neg Sh(S_1)$, and then deduce $\neg Sh(S_1)$. Then, taking i = 1, we have $\neg Sh(S_1) \rightarrow \neg Sh(S_2)$, and again deduce $\neg Sh(S_2)$. Repeating this process, we obtain $\neg Sh(S_N)$. This contradicts (P2).

Therefore, at least one of the premises must be rejected or rewritten: either the end-point intuition is wrong, but few people are willing to advocate this position; or "the process does not consist of extremely small steps", but this conflicts with physiological continuity; or the tolerance principle fails somewhere.

III. Why is the “Principle of Tolerance” Hard to Reject?

Rejecting (P3) is equivalent to admitting that there exists an i such that S_i is not feces while S_{i+1} is feces, despite the minimal difference between them. This incurs an explanatory burden: which specific minor difference (an extra second, an extra drop of water, a forward shift of 0.1 millimeter) triggers the “sudden activation” of a strongly normative predicate?

A common way of “evading” this problem is to claim that the moment of expulsion is a drastic change, thus allowing for the categorical flip. However, if we narrow the time - step to 1 millisecond before and after the expulsion, the chemical composition hardly changes. If the categorical flip occurs merely because it “passes through the anus”, then “shit” would be defined as a positional predicate, which contradicts the common statement that “it's already feces in the stomach”. In other words, the tolerance principle is appealing because “shit” doesn't seem to be toggled by a single microscopic event.

4. Three “Tangency Point Schemes” and Their Costs

To preserve clear boundaries, people often attempt to tie "shit" to a certain cut-off point.

(1) Location cut-off point: Once the content enters the colon/rectum, it is considered feces. Cost: The content does not teleport as a whole but rather partially enters while partially remains. The question "Is it considered feces as long as a part of it enters?" will bring back the ambiguity of "how much/which part counts".

(2) Component cut-off point: Excreta is defined when a certain chemical/microbial proportion is reached. Cost: The proportion is a continuous variable, and the threshold must be justified by external purposes, such as hygiene, medicine, and etiquette. Once the purpose changes, the threshold also changes. If the threshold is merely a convention, then "excreta" is not solely determined by natural kinds. If the threshold is natural, it is necessary to explain where nature has drawn the discrete line, which is exactly what the sorites paradox chain interrogates.

(3) Functional cut-off point: What is no longer utilized by the body and is systematically excreted is feces. Cost: The cessation of "utilization" is also gradual: the absorption efficiency decreases and the utilizable part reduces, but there is hardly a moment when it jumps from "utilizable" to "unutilizable".

These schemes indicate that we can indeed precisely define "shit" within specific systems (public health, medical testing, and daily etiquette each have their own "cut - off points"), yet the boundaries often stem from practical purposes rather than inherent breaks in the digestive process.

V. Three Types of Classic Responses: Which Kind of “Clarity” Do You Want?

(1) Cognitivism: There are indeed precise boundaries, but in principle, we do not know where they are. Williamson (1994) interprets vagueness as a form of ignorance: the scope of application of a predicate is precise, but its boundaries are unknowable. In this example, there exists a precise moment t*: before t*, it is not feces; after t*, it is feces.

(2) Supervaluation: There are multiple “legitimate precisifications”; a proposition is “definitely true” only if it is true under all precisifications. Fine (1975) systematically defended this idea. In this example, for some S_i in the middle section, it counts as feces under some precisifications but not under others, thus resulting in undecidability.

(3) Contextualism: The process of precisification varies with context and conversational purpose. Shapiro (2006) incorporated this variability into the core of the theory. In this example, different cut - off points will be "selected" in the hygiene context, the dining - table context, and the medical context. For a systematic comparison of these positions, refer to the review by Keefe (2000).

VI. Contextualized Supervaluation: Giving "Usable Vagueness" to Shit

I propose to combine (2) and (3). Semantically, the term "shit" corresponds to a set of acceptable precisifications (with different weightings for dimensions such as location, composition, and

function). Pragmatically, in a specific context, the set of acceptable precisifications is narrowed down through the purpose and regulatory practices. As a result, a stable judgment can be made in most situations, yet divisions into undecidable cases may still occur at the marginal stages.

In this way, we can not only retain the certainty of endpoints (S_0 is not feces under all reasonable precisifications; S_N is feces under all reasonable precisifications), but also explain that the reason why the sorites argument holds is not that we lack the knowledge of digestion, but that language allows multiple ways of "drawing the boundary here".

VII. Conclusion

The sorites argument regarding feces does not tell us "when feces start." Instead, it reveals that when a continuous process encounters strong normative predicates, vagueness is a structural product. We can interpret it as the epistemic view of hidden boundaries plus ignorance, or as the contextual supervaluation of multiple precisifications plus contextual selection. This paper opts for the latter approach, which not only preserves the operability of daily judgments but also acknowledges the institutional nature and rewritability of boundaries.